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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1969-1971

Coverage Date: 1921-1971

Place Coverage: Dobe Area, Northwest Botswana

Section Title(S): Chapter 15 Growing Older

The !Kung do not think of themselves in terms of chronological age. They measure the passage of time by less precise strokes—the changes of the seasons, the cycles of the moon, and the rhythms of day and night. The human life span is described as an orderly progression of the biological and social events that most people experience. Childhood, for example, is seen as a sequence: the onset of social smiling, sitting alone, standing, walking, and learning to talk. Similar sequences describe adulthood and aging. Although they do not keep track of numerical age, the !Kung are acutely aware of relative age. Since age is associated with status, “who is older”—be it a few years or a few days—is extremely important and affects all relationships. Except for the occasional visitor from a distant area, people usually know the age ranking of everyone around them.

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A term of respect—the suffix *n!a* attached to a name—acknowledges the attainment of full adulthood. It may occasionally be applied to a younger person to applaud high achievement (in hunting, trancing, or playing a musical instrument, for example), but it is usually given to people in their forties, a time of great vigor and productivity for both men and women. It may also be used to distinguish them from younger people with the same name. By their late fifties, however, *n!a n!a* may be used to express the greater respect that comes with their advancing age. *≠Da*, meaning “quite old,” describes people in their late sixties, and those who live into their seventies and beyond often joke about being *≠da !ki*, literally, “so old as to be almost be dead.”

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For most !Kung, the rate of aging seems comparable to what it is in our own and other cultures. The constant exposure to the wind and sun dries and wrinkles the skin early in life. But when anthropologists' guesses of !Kung ages were checked against painstaking age verifications made by Nancy Howell, the guesses  322 turned out to be quite close. This might be explained by the fact that the !Kung do not put on excess weight as they age, thus keeping a youthful appearance.

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